

OCR SOFTWARE

For a paperless office to become a reality, one needs to convert a large amount of printed data into a digital format. This is where OCR software steps in. In the past year, while there have not been that many advancements in the look and feel and features offered by OCR software, there has been a marked improvement in the accuracy of these software in scanning and converting printed matter into an editable digital format.

Like speech recognition, OCR software is going to become increasingly faster and accurate when working with printed documents. The software is going to evolve to recognise an individual's handwriting. This will spawn a whole new generation of devices incorporating advanced OCR capabilities. The next time you need to take notes, you may well be scribbling them on your handheld device, ready to be ported to any digital format you might want to convert it to. It looks like the keyboard is going to be on its way out!



Fine Reader 5.0 Pro



Accuracy and affordable cost make this OCR software stand out

This software featured the distinction of speedy performance along with the capability of recognising even the finer elements of printed text such as superscripts and other smaller details such as symbols and punctuation characters. It also excelled in maintaining the layout of other elements on the scanned pages such as pictures and formatting elements.

- + Retains layout
- + Reasonably priced
- + Good accuracy

Price: Not available
Contact: Vikmans Multimedia
Phone: 011-6472325
E-mail: manish@vikmans.com
Web site: www.abbyy.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

Worthy Mentions

Text Bridge Pro Millennium

+ Plenty of text recognition features
Price: Rs 3,700
Web site: www.scansoft.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

Newssoft Presto! OCR Pro 4.01

+ High detection rates over a range of print media
Price: Rs 4,700
Web site: Newssoftinc.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: NA 1999: NA 1998: NA

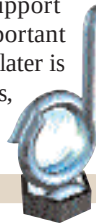
OFFICE SUITES

Office suites haven't changed too much since the basic components are still word processors, spreadsheets, presentation tools and PIM applications. What has changed considerably, however, is the level of integration between these programs. Office suites, which were initially just a collection of applications that were bundled together to offer greater value in offices, are now a basic requirement for every computer user. Another addition has been the inclusion of support for publishing information on the Internet. With the consolidation of programs such as contact managers, word processors and databases applications, these office suites help us accomplish tasks more efficiently.

With the competition from vendors such as Lotus and Corel diminishing every year, it is not likely that we are going to see any dramatic new features in the near future. There will be subtle refinements in the usability of the software, improvements in the publishing and printing options and support for XML in particular. Another important feature that might gain significance later is wider implementation of Smart Tags, which are supported by Office XP.



Microsoft Office XP (Standard)



Whether it's recovering documents or applying different formatting styles, the Task Pane makes working with this software painless

Microsoft Office XP scores in the sheer numbers of features that it offers. With the addition of Smart Tags, problems regarding formatting in the earlier versions have been resolved. The Task Pane adds another window to the interface and displays information related to the task that you are performing. Office XP has improved collaborative features. It also integrates tightly with the Web and other Microsoft applications.

+ Text-to-speech capability
+ Task Pane and Smart Tags makes working easier
Price: Rs 20,500
Contact: Microsoft Corporation

India Pvt Ltd
Phone: 011-6294600
Fax: 011-6292650
E-mail: msconnect@microsoft.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

Worthy Mentions

Lotus Smart Suite 9.6

+ Advanced document-tracking features
+ Extremely feature rich
Price: Rs 5,500
Contact: Lotus Development
Phone: 022-2322024
Fax: 022-2322026
E-mail: india@lotus.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

StarOffice 5.2

+ Free for use
+ Has a good style list
Price: Free for download
Contact: StarOffice
Web site: www.staroffice.com
Reviewed in: July 2001

PREVIOUS WINNERS 2000: Microsoft Office 2000 1999: Microsoft Office 2000 1998: Microsoft Office 97 Professional

